from China in the foreseeable future. He appeared to take at face value the repeated references by China desiring friendship. To those who felt otherwise, he warned against losing our sense of perspective and giving way to unreasoning fears.

Each one eventually was to temper their view with some realization of the complications of a modus vivendi. The choice of words in what was an internal debate is obviously not quite diplomatic. But their gut instincts nevertheless were articulated quite clearly. One bet on a world of left-wing romanticism; the other voted for time-tested calculations about neighbours, especially big ones.

There were naturally multiple expressions of this divergence in approach, and that played out in the ensuing decades. As competition and even conflict characterized certain periods, public attitudes also started to take root accordingly. These may or may not have been shared by the governments of the day. Some displayed a consideration that was at variance with popular sentiment or even sought to shape opinion by advancing new objectives. Others were more hard-headed and would not let difficult issues be brushed under the carpet. Whatever the nuances, the defining imagery of diplomatic complacency remains the 1954 Panchsheel declaration.

If there is a common thread in the tendency to expect best-case scenarios, it is the optimism of a particular brand of Indian internationalism. One illustration of this Nehruvian approach was in the debate about permanent membership of the UNSC. Whether it was feasible to successfully assert our claim at that point of time is an issue in itself, and would we have been granted the same consideration had roles been reversed is a corollary to it. But there was not even an attempt by India to leverage this issue for national gain, either with China bilaterally or with other major powers. It appeared that the basics of diplomacy had given way to the influence of ideology. Instead, Nehru’s decision in 1955 was to declare that India was not in a hurry to enter the Security Council at that time, even though it ought to be there. The first step, instead, was for China to take its rightful place. After that, the question of India could be considered separately. And no surprise, far from reciprocating Nehru’s ‘China First’ policy, we are still waiting for that country to express support for our own similar ambitions!